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The Poetry and Autobiography of the *Bâbur-nâma*

STEPHEN F. DALE

اگر شاعر باشی جهد کن
تا سخن تو سهل ممتنع باشد

If you would be a poet strive for
your style to be clear but inimitable.

Kai Kâ'ûs Ibn Iskandar,
Qâbûs-nâma
(Levy 1951, 109)

Literary biography is a difficult art to practice when the subject is a premodern Muslim poet. Even in the work of such explicitly autobiographical western writers as the twentieth-century Russian poet Anna Akhmatova the relationship between art and life can be tantalizingly ambiguous. In the case of most well-known classical Muslim poets, though, the connection between life and literature is usually indeterminable. To personalize the lyrics of the great fourteenth-century Persian poet Hâfiz is as problematic as trying to glean autobiographical details from Shakespeare's sonnets. The reasons are essentially the same. Little is known of these poets' lives, and their poems exemplify lyric and panegyric genres that were not intended to be autobiographical or idiosyncratic. Neither Hafiz nor Shakespeare were Romantics, and they did not write introspective or self-revealing poems. In only a few instances are the lives of premodern Muslim poets sufficiently well-known so that their work can be understood to reflect or refract their lives in both obvious and subtle ways. An exceptionally important example is Zâhir al-Dîn Muhammad Bâbur, the founder in 1526 of the Mughul empire of India and a poet in both Persian and Türkî, or

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Chaghatai Turkish.¹ Unlike most poets Babur provides an autobiographical context for his verse, his prose memoir generally known as the *Bâbur-nâma*, and he not only quotes many of his own poems in this text but frequently explains the circumstance of their composition.² Consequently Babur's poetry can be read autobiographically—as a measure of his literary ambitions, as a commentary on his career, and sometimes as a gauge of his emotions. In his work it is possible to explore the connection between experience and verse, between prose and poetry. It is a unique opportunity in the literary history of Central Asia, the Islamic world, and India for the premodern period.

Babur's poetry can best be understood within the framework of his life, which he describes so compellingly in his memoirs. At the time of his birth in 1483 he was merely one of dozens of *mîrzâs* or princes who were heirs to the Central Asian, Iranian, and Afghan conquests of Tēmur, or Tīmūr in the more commonly used Persian spelling. Babur was a fifth-generation patrilineal descendant of Timur (d.1405)—and a fifteenth-generation matrilineal descendant of Chinggis Qan or, in Persian, Chingiz Khân (d.1227). As a result of his patriliney he thought of himself as a Timurid and a Turk, even though he had many matrilineal relatives descended from Chingiz Khan. In his twelfth year he inherited his father's Timurid patrimony of Andijân, a small appanage but one strategically located along the silk road in the rich Farghâna valley, east of Samarkand. During the next decade he struggled with Timurid relatives and the Chingizid Uzbek leader, Shîbânî Khân, for the right to claim Samarkand and Timur's imperial inheritance. In 1500 he briefly seized Samarkand from Shibani Khan's forces, only to abandon it to them within months, and after losing Andijan too, he eventually fled south to Afghanistan and in 1504 occupied Kâbul. The city was then an obscure, impoverished provincial outpost that Timur had garrisoned after he sacked Delhi and quickly withdrew from India in 1398. Kabul had been governed until 1402 by Mîrzâ Beg Kâbulî, one of Babur's paternal or Timurid uncles, and previous Timurid occupation explains Babur's claim. Babur ruled Kabul province and much of eastern Afghanistan for the next twenty-two years, using it first as a base to recapture Samarkand briefly in 1511 before once again being driven out by the Uzbeks. Gradually and reluctantly he turned his attention to India and from Kabul mounted a series of plundering raids and military campaigns that culminated with his victory over Afghan forces in 1526. He thus initiated the South Asian Timurid renaissance, although later his state would be inaccurately identified as the "Mughal" empire.³

¹Bâbur refers to his native language as Türkî. As Janos Eckmann points out, Chaghatai, the name of Chingiz Khân's second son who was assigned to rule Transoxiana and eastern Turkistan, was not widely used in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries as the name of this language. Mîr 'Alî Shîr Navâ'î of Harât was one of the few who did so, primarily to describe the literary Turki that he himself developed (Eckmann 1966, 1–10).

²Two texts of the *Bâbur-nâma* have recently been published. Each has distinct advantages. Eiji Mano has collated four Turki texts and published the most accurate edition available (Mano 1995–96). W. M. Thackston Jr. has published the text, the the Mughul-period Persian translation, and an improved and stylistically contemporary English translation in an extremely useful parallel format in three volumes (Thackston 1993). Neither has published notes that replace those in A. S. Beveridge's early-twentieth-century English translation (repr. 1969) or the "modern" Turkish translation of the eminent Turcologist, Resit Rahmeti Arat (1943). Jean-Louis Bacqué-Grammont has published a beautifully illustrated French translation (1985), and Thackston has issued an equally beautifully illustrated one-volume edition of his English translation (Thackston 1996).

³The term "Mughal" is an incorrect dynastic term for Babur's descendants because it is the misspelling of a misnomer. Not only is the Persian and Turki word **مغل** or **مغول** more

Text and Poetic Context: the *Babur-nama*

Babur died in 1530, leaving behind an incompletely subjugated kingdom, an unfinished autobiographical memoir, a *diwân* or volume of Turki poetry, and versified works on sufism and Islamic law. The *Babur-nama* was immediately recognized as an unusual text when British-Indian officials first translated it in the early nineteenth century (Thackston 1996, 11–15). Babur's original title and his purpose in writing have to be surmised because of the loss of a large portion of the text, including the critical opening chapters in which he narrates the first eleven years of his life; but the contents and style of his prose narrative are distinct from other premodern Muslim memoirs (Dale 1990, 37, 40–42; Thackston 1996, 9–10). He conveys a sense of his humanity in a manner that is scarcely encountered in Islamic or Indian literature—and only rarely in that of Europe or China in the early modern period. Perhaps only in the fragmentary personal record of the Manzhou Kangxi emperor (1654–1722) is it possible to find comparable feeling expressed by an imperial figure (Spence 1974, xii–xiii). In his spare Turki prose Babur describes moments of indecision, regret, fear of death, and a host of other emotions that premodern Muslim writers rarely ascribe to themselves or describe in others. He conveys a sense of psychological uncertainty and ambiguity of the moment that Roy Pascal, one of the founders of modern autobiographical studies, believes to be an identifying characteristic of the best autobiographies. Pascal, indeed, writes that “the *Baburnama* would occupy a significant place in the history of autobiography had it belonged to Europe” (Pascal 1960, 22).

Babur also includes one of the characteristic conceits of the later European autobiographical tradition when he insists that he is being absolutely truthful and unbiased.

What I have said is all fact. I do not intend to aggrandize myself with what I have written. What I have written is the truth.

(Thackston 1996, 122)

Yet as John Paul Eakin has recently observed in his elegant critique of the autobiographical genre, it is impossible to know whether autobiographers present themselves truthfully or accurately based solely upon their works. “Whether the self, that ‘certain intricate watermark,’ is literally discovered, made ‘visible’ in autobiography, or is only invented by it as a kind of signature, a kind of writing, is beyond our knowing” (Eakin 1985, 278). Like other persuasive autobiographers, Babur “truthfully” interprets his life from his own perspective. In doing so he

accurately rendered as Mughul or Mughûl, but however it is spelled the word means Mongol, while Babur's descendants identified themselves as Timurids, since patrilineage determined identity. Babur refers to himself either as a Timurid or a Turk; his great, great grandson, Shâh Jahân, the builder of the Taj Mahal, identified himself as the second Timur! Occasionally, Babur describes his maternal Chingizid relatives, descended from Chingiz Khan through Chaghatai, as “Mughuls” to distinguish them from the Uzbeks, although the latter were also Chingizids. More often he uses the term Mughul pejoratively to refer to Mongols “of the horde,” the uncivilized—that is, uncitified, non-Iranized, still nomadic or seminomadic Mongols who, he often complained, were rapacious and politically unreliable. However, given the widespread use of Mughal for the South Asian Timurids, it would be preferable to adopt John Richards's recent compromise, while modifying his spelling, and refer to Babur's dynasty as the Timurid-Mughuls (Richards).

naturally emphasizes “facts” that would appeal to his most important potential audience, the Timurid and Chingizid aristocrats of Central Asia, possible competitors for power or potential sources of legitimacy for Babur’s claim to be the seal of the Timurids.

Babur’s self-presentation differs considerably from that of Rousseau and such “classic” European and American autobiographers of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries as Wordsworth, Franklin, and Goethe. He does not indulge in Rousseau’s intense introspection, and rarely provides intimate personal or family details or even a physical description of himself. His work is closer in spirit to the Italian renaissance autobiographers Cardano and Cellini. Apart from offering occasional insights into his own emotional state, Babur presents a portrait of himself as a supremely confident Timurid prince who shared the values of the Turco-Mongol aristocracy. He must be addressing such men when he claims to have surpassed the military achievements of Sultân Hasayn Bâîqarâ of Harât (r.1470–1506), the last great Timurid ruler of the Iranian-Central Asian region (Thackston 1996, 122). Babur would also have wanted these men to believe that when he visited Harat in 1506, just after Sultan Husayn Mirza’s death, he did so, as he writes, primarily because he was selflessly concerned for the “good name” of the Timurid dynasty (Thackston 1996, 230). These same Chingizid and Timurid nobles are also, presumably, his intended audience when he describes with relish the many instances when he and his entourage drank heavily and consumed *ma’jun*, a drugged confection laced with bhang.

Babur narrates many of these outings during the period he ruled in Kabul, such as the three-day trip that he took with a small group of retainers to view fall colors in the famous Istalif mountain meadows, north of Kabul, between 29 October and 1 November 1519. Speaking of this area, the memory of whose beauty easily brings twentieth-century Afghans to tears—or poetry—Babur writes:

On Monday we went to Istalif to tour the autumn harvest. We ate ma’jun, and that night it rained a lot. . . . The next morning, at a wine party in this same garden, we drank until night, then had a morning draught the next morning. We got drunk and went to sleep. At midday we rode out of Istalif, having some ma’jun along the way. In the afternoon we came to Bihzadi [near Kabul]. The autumn was beautiful. While touring the harvest my companions who were inclined to wine began to agitate for some. Although we had had some *ma’jun*, since the autumn colors were so beautiful, we sat down under the colorful trees and drank.

(Thackston 1996, 301)

When wondering why a professed Sunni Muslim would include such incidents in his memoirs, it is worth remembering that Babur was a Turco-Mongol aristocrat with a social ethos that in certain respects resembled that of the tribal poets of pre-Islamic Arabia. The Arabic phrase, “taking the morning draught,” originated among these writers whose genre of *fakhr*, boasting or self-glorification, often featured descriptions of drunkenness as well as feats of horsemanship and hunting (Tayib 1983, 44, 81–83). Babur wrote for a similar audience, albeit one at least superficially Islamized, not for the pious *‘ulamâ* of Bukhara or Delhi. Timurid *mirzas* and Chingizid *khans*, most of them socialized to appreciate prolonged, raucous parties, would almost certainly have recognized Babur as one of themselves and laughed at his description of another party that he held on 10 January 1520. On this occasion Babur reports that he said “in jest that anyone who sang a song in Persian would be allowed to drink a cup of wine. . . . Then it was proposed that anyone who sang a song in Turkish

would be allowed to drink a cup" (Thackston 1996, 305). Here was Turco-Mongol camaraderie, a kind of social legitimacy for a potential successor of Timur!

Apart from its obvious autobiographical elements, Babur's text is famous for two stylistic qualities that help to convey a sense of social reality or narrative truth: its direct, simple language and precise, remarkably detailed social and geographical descriptions. Babur wrote in a direct, unadorned prose, a marked contrast to prevailing literary norms of Timurid and Iranian historical writing in Persian or Turki that valued elaborate rhetorical embellishment. His choice of style may reflect one or several influences: his own attenuated education, the lack of a voluminous Turki historical literature written in the complex, elaborate Persian tradition, or the preference of a man of affairs for clarity. As for Babur's descriptions, they are not only detailed but are known to be exceptionally precise where their accuracy can be measured, as in his many careful accounts of natural phenomena. When he portrays individuals, this quality gives his work the particularity that has been said to be "vital to the success—that is, the truth—of an autobiography" (McWilliam 1992, 5). Typical of this quality is his early sketch of his father, 'Umar Shaykh Mîrzâ:

He was short in stature, had a round beard and a fleshy face, and was fat. He wore his tunic so tight that to fasten the ties, he had to hold in his stomach; if he let himself go, it often happened that the ties broke. He was unceremonious in both dress and speech. . . . In summertime, except when he was holding court, he wore a Mongol cap.

(Thackston 1996, 40)

Babur's capacity for evocative portraiture resembles Tolstoy's talent for acute characterization. He has a novelist's eye for telling detail similar to the ability that Isaiah Berlin notes in Tolstoy, whom he praises as a "genius . . . for marvelously accurate reproduction of the irreproducible, the almost miraculous evocation of the full, untranslatable individuality of the individual . . ." (Berlin 1953, 41).

One possible clue to Babur's style and precise reporting may be found in the original title of his work, which was almost certainly not the *Babur-nama*, but وقائع *vaqâ'i* or "events" (Mano 1996, xxxv–xxxvi). This is the title of the Mughul-period Persian translation of Babur's text; it is also the title of each of his chapters, e.g., "The Events of 908." The *vaqâ'î-nivîs* was a well-known official in early modern Islamic states, one who reported on conditions or events in rulers' domains. The most important quality of such officials was accuracy, not rhetorical embellishment that could obfuscate meaning. Certainly it is obvious that when Babur dwelt at length on the beauties of Harat and arcane Hindu customs or the exotic flora and fauna of India that he was acting as a kind of royal reporter or "intelligencer" for his compatriots in Central Asia, where he hoped to return one day. He did not offer similar cultural essays on Turan, which his potential readers knew very well. However, he maintained this style throughout the text, when providing genealogies or narrating military campaigns, although his particular report was animated both by an exceptionally lively intelligence and a profound Timurid self-confidence.

The report genre does not, though, account for his habit of quoting poetry throughout the text. This was a rhetorical characteristic associated with traditional historical writing rather than the intelligence report. He occasionally refers to his own work as a *tâ'rikh*, a chronicle or narrative history, and it is easy to understand how Babur might use this word as a synonym for his chronology of events. Neither in style nor content, however, does the *Babur-nama* resemble the traditional, formal

ta'rikh of the professional historians, usually a dry narrative of military and political events, frequently couched in allusive baroque prose. Once again it is worth recalling that Babur was neither a religious scholar, nor a professional historian nor a court poet, any of whom are likely to have written easily recognizable traditional genres with elaborate literary artifice. Yet, like contemporary historians, he uses poetry to provide apposite sayings, decorating and legitimizing prosaic ideas with aphorisms of classical poets. More often though he quotes his own verse. He had precedents too for this practice. Kai Ka'us ibn Iskandar, in his late-eleventh-century mirror for princes' work, the *Qâbûs-nâma*, had also composed poetry for his own prose text, but one of a very different kind, in which experience was abstracted to form moral and political lessons for his son. If Babur had lived to revise his narrative of events he may possibly have revised his work and written something closer to a mirror for South Asian Timurid princes, but his unfinished volume is characterized by particularity rather than generality. Most of his *Babur-nama* poems represent occasional verses that have an obvious, immediate relevance for his life.

The Poetic Art

Babur attached great importance to his literary reputation. He wanted readers of the *Babur-nama* to understand that he had worked diligently to master the craft of poetry, and obviously hoped that his verse would be admired in literary circles among his Timurid and Chingizid relations and associates. Near the end of his life he distributed copies of many verses to his sons and compatriots (Thackston 1996, 422), seeking, presumably, literary immortality. He first alludes to his poems while narrating events for 1499–1500, when he still controlled and even briefly lived in his Andijan patrimony. Just after his first marriage he composed Persian couplets to illustrate his distracted, lovesick state, although he did not describe feelings for his young wife, but depicted his emotional tumult after becoming enamored with a boy in the bazar named, interestingly, Baburi. In doing so he was conforming to classical Persian literary conventions. These did not encourage writers to commemorate rites of passage in their lives but provided centuries of precedent for depicting distant, unresolved infatuations. In the following year during his brief occupation of Samarqand, he reports writing Turki couplets, even copying one of them on the back of the letter that he sent to Mîr 'Ali Shîr Navâ'î in Harat (d. 1501) (Thackston 1996, 123). Nava'i, an official and confidante of Sultan Husayn Baiqara, was the founder of what has come to be known as classical Turki verse. At the time of Babur's letter he was widely known both as the outstanding Turki poet and as an exceptionally dynamic patron of the arts (Subtelny 1979). As a young Timurid sending his own poems to Nava'i from Timur's capital, Samarqand, Babur may have been seeking to have himself publicly recognized as a literate, therefore culturally legitimate ruler. He makes explicit his early desire to acquire a literary reputation when, just two years later, he describes in the *Babur-nama* his first attempts to master the poetic craft during a period of enforced inactivity in Tashkent.

In 1502 Babur lost both Samarqand and Andijan and fled as a refugee to seek military aid from one of his maternal or Chingizid uncles, Sultan Mahmûd Khân, the ruler of Tashkent. While in the city he also took the opportunity to solicit the Khan's critique of his first complete Turki poem.

I had composed the following quatrain, but I had some hesitation about the rhyme because at that time I had not yet made a study of the technique of poetry. The khan

had a poetic nature and composed poetry, although his successful ghazals were few. I presented my quatrain to him and told him of my doubts, but I did not receive a satisfactory answer. Probably he had not studied the techniques of poetry much either.

(Thackston 1996, 136)

In seeking his uncle's literary advice Babur may have only been making the flattering gesture of a desperate man. Yet it was also reasonable of him to assume that the Khan, whom he affectionately called "dâdâ" or father, would be a skilled poet. The Khan's own father, Yûnus Khân, a descendant of Chingiz Khan's second son Chaghatai, had assimilated the cultural traits of Perso-Islamic aristocratic society during a nearly two-decade exile in Iran and Iraq. As admiringly depicted by Babur's Chingizid cousin, Mîrzâ Muhammad Dûghlât, Yunas Khan

excelled in penmanship, painting and other accomplishments conformable with a healthy nature, and was well-trained in singing and instrumental music. . . . He was graced with . . . perfect manners, was unequaled in bravery and heroism, and excelled especially in archery.

(Dughlat 1972, II:155)

Yunas Khan was an exceptionally accomplished Chingizid—from the Iranian perspective—yet partly sedentarized Chingizids and even more so Timurid *mirzas* had absorbed Perso-Islamic court culture in such Central Asian and eastern Iranian urban centers as Samarqand, Bukhara, and Harat (Lentz and Lowrey 1989). Many Timurid rulers of these and lesser cities were competent poets. Nearly all of them lavishly patronized poets, calligraphers, musicians, and painters to the degree that modern scholars often characterize the century after Timur's death as the Timurid renaissance (Roux 1986, chap. 2). While the characterization of this period as a renaissance has been questioned, these *mirzas* undoubtedly presided over a magnificent florescence of Perso-Islamic and Turkic culture, competing for artists, writers, and musicians as did the German and Austrian nobility of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century (Subtelny 1983, 1988).

Even growing up in remote Andijan with its predominant Turco-Mongol linguistic and political heritage, Babur absorbed these Perso-Islamic ideals. He considered the refined accomplishments—calligraphy, music, and poetry are most often mentioned—to be attributes of sovereignty, when combined, of course, with an authentic Timurid lineage. He ridiculed simple steppe Mongols, even his Khan dada's older brother, Beg Tîlba ("the fool"), "who," wrote Babur, "had been in Moghulistan all his life and . . . had never entered a civilized country . . ." (Thackston 1996, 109). Babur uses the term *vilâyat*, an agrarian or sedentary region, for "civilized country." His implicit distinction between people like himself and the Beg Tilbas of his time is analogous to that which Sinicized Mongols of the Yüan dynasty made between themselves and the Mongols of the steppe (Dardess 1973). In contrast, Babur praised his cousin Bâisunghur Mîrzâ, who in the 1490s had ruled Hisâr, just north of the Oxus river, as:

a just and humane, poetically inclined, and learned prince. . . . he was too fond of the wine cup, but when he was not drinking he performed his prayers. He was moderate in his liberality and generosity. He wrote the nasta'liq script very well, and his hand was not bad at painting either. He composed some marvelous poetry. His pen name was Adili, but he did not compose enough poetry to make a divan. . . .

Baysunghur Mirza's poetry was so popular in Samarqand that there were few houses in which you would not find some of his poems.

(Thackston 1996, 106)

Baisunghur Mirza appears to have represented Babur's princely ideal, a man whose drinking was the only apparent trace of his steppe heritage, although even *bazm*, or drinking at feasts, was a well-known element of both pre-Islamic Iran and Perso-Islamic culture (Meisami 1987, 248–49). It seems likely that Babur hoped his verses would also one day be widely read in Samarqand. By the end of his life he had at least completed a *diwan* or volume of poems, surpassing his cousin in literary output at least, but there is no evidence that Babur became a popular poet in Timur's capital or elsewhere in Turan in the sixteenth century—or anytime later.

Babur then was born into a ruling elite, most of whose members valued art and calligraphy, literary and musical skills (Lentz and Lowrey 1989; Grönke 1993). On the basis of his character sketches of Chingizid and Timurid nobles, it is obvious that poetry was the most accessible and widely practiced art, but it was also one intimately linked with calligraphy and often with music as well. The stylish calligraphic rendering of a poem and its musicality contributed to the complete artistic experience of artful verse. Babur, who spoke approvingly of Baisunghur Mirza's mastery of the flowing *nasta'liq* style commonly used in illuminated manuscripts of Persian poetical works, himself invented a new calligraphic style, the *khatt-i Baburi*, although no known examples of it are extant (Thackston 1996, 186; Beveridge 1969, 228). The close association of poetry and calligraphy was a common feature of early modern Islamic court culture, whether in Central Asia, Mughul India, Safavid Iran, or the Ottoman empire (Silay 1994, 48). The musicality of poems was evident when they were recited, but beyond this quality conferred by meter and rhyme much verse was sung (Meisami 1987, 241–42; Schimmel 1989, 940–41). Babur also composed music, although he does not say if he intended it for poetry (Thackston 1996, 305). Modern Indo-Muslim examples of this tradition are the poems sung at Chishtiyâ shrine in Delhi (Qureshi) and Vikram Seth's fictional representation of the Lucknow courtesan tradition (Seth 1993, 82–88).

None of these features of aristocratic court culture was peculiar to the Timurid world. In cosmopolitan tenth-century Baghdad, the capital of the 'Abbasid caliphate, stylish speech and literary art were attributes of the *zurafa'*, the refined people, practitioners of humanistic belle lettres or *adab* court culture (Meisami 1987, 17). At the same period in Heian Japan, poetic artifice was the sine qua non for the successful courtier in Lady Murasaki's aristocratic world (Morris 1969, 190–200). Japanese nobles who could render verse in elegant calligraphy were often acclaimed to be individuals of exceptional stature, even of moral worth, a parallel with the religious prestige which exceptionally able Muslim calligraphers enjoyed (Schimmel 1970, 1–2; 1994, chap. 4). Heian courtiers may have taken the allusive, muted, and subtle love poem to excessively refined heights, but they, like the 'Abbasid *zurafa'*, resembled the idealized Italian Renaissance courtier (Castiglione 1976; Morris 1969, 209). Common to all these widely separated aristocratic traditions was an ideal, if not always conceived in precisely the same terms, of courtly love. In the Persian and Turki literary world of the Timurid period the *ghazal* and the *rubai'* were the principal poetic genres for this expression. Babur's *diwan* consists overwhelmingly of these verse forms, although he also used other poems to express his emotions and opinions in the *Babur-nama*.

The *ghazal* was the most widely practiced genre among Muslim poets who wrote in Persian, Ottoman Turkish, or Turki during Babur's lifetime, and when Babur describes his early efforts to master the poetic art he is principally concerned with this lyric form. A poem of five to fifteen distichs or couplets with a rhyme scheme of *aa, ba, ca*, the *ghazal* is described in a thirteenth-century work on Iranian poetry as "any short poem on the subjects of the arts of love" (Lewis 1995, 201). Whether such verses were originally addressed exclusively to men or women is not clear, although by the fifteenth-century men were the beloved as often as not. However, it is almost certainly a mistake to try to specify that this genre reflected exclusively either heterosexual or homoerotic norms, for the ambiguity of either author or subject seems to be inherent in the nature of much court poetry. What has been written about the ambiguity of sexual references in conventions of Japanese court poetry can probably also apply to the *ghazal*:

as courtly love became increasingly codified, it grew fixed in forms that did not always reflect current relations between the sexes. It became, in short, a fiction like our [European] courtly love. . . . In composing love poems for such a conventional code, men might write poems whose speakers were women, and women poems whose speakers were men.

(Brower and Miner 1961, 431)

The obvious major difference between the two traditions is the prevalence of women authors in Heian Japan.

From the late eleventh century on, Hafiz and other Iranian poets expanded the subject of the *ghazal* to include mystical, that is sufi, and panegyric topics, and this development reached its apogee in the *ghazals* of Hafiz (Rypka 1968, 94–99 and Meisami 1987, 237). Apart from his many *ghazals* Babur wrote mainly *rubā'i* or quatrains, a lyric form made famous in the West by Fitzgerald's rendering of 'Umar Khayyam's *Rubaiyat*, in reality a collection of separate poems with the rhyme scheme *aaba*. Both the *ghazal* and the *rubā'i* usually included a *takhallus*, the poet's pen name, given in the *maqta'*, the poem's final couplet. Other commonly used verse forms at this time were the *qasīda* or eulogy—Babur was periodically the object of such poems but wrote none—and the *qit'a* or fragment, which, as its name may suggest, was a more spontaneous genre that Babur frequently wrote, although he did not regard the *qit'a* as true poetry (Stebleva 1982, 173–74). Finally, there was the *masnavi*, a series of rhyming couplets usually employed for long narratives, tales, and histories. Professional poets frequently wrote such verse, but Babur seems to have written only one, perhaps because he did not have time to concentrate on such ambitious works in his tumultuous life. However, he did write extended versified essays on sufism and religious law.

Babur was not alone in regarding the *ghazal* as the most important verse form for an aspiring poet to master. In Central Asia, Iran, and Muslim India, and among the Ottoman elite, it was often equated with the poetic art in this period. Poets were evaluated by the quality of their *ghazals* (Silay 1994, 52). The *ghazal* was probably most widely prized as a love poem that chronicled the poet's infatuation, his agonized separation from the object of his desire, the cruel indifference of the beloved, and the poet's inevitable, fatalistic resignation. Many poets, though, employed the genre to depict the mystical fervor of sufis, practitioners of an interiorized spiritualism, or even and especially with Hafiz, love or praise in the *qasida* tradition for the patron. Given the allegorical nature of much Persian verse and the widespread use of sufi imagery,

a particular poem might seem to evoke a profane love or elaborations of earthly delights, while the lover might actually be a sufi and the beloved, with long disheveled tresses, god. Wine consumed by this spiritual lover connoted spiritual intoxication. Utilizing these metaphors a court poet might also write a paean to his patron, who then assumed the role of the beloved, with the power to withhold favors or to reward the author.

As authors of Persian, Ottoman, and Turki *ghazals* often employed the same imagery, whatever their own profession or religious inclination, it is usually difficult or simply impossible to distill pure personal, religious, or political sentiments from the metaphors of a particular poem. Babur himself was a disciple of the Naqshbandî sufi order, but he was hardly a practicing sufi in his everyday life. Some of the verse that he wrote towards the end of his life, when he was sick in India and sensing his mortality, may convey feelings of sufi devotionism, but the spirit of most of his earlier *ghazals* and *rubā'i* too seems closer to that of the *rend* (Hillmann 1988, 97). A poet, a lover, and a drinker, the *rend* was one almost ritually devoted to life's transitory pleasures. Similar in certain compelling respects to the Heian Japanese ideals of *irogonomi* and *suki*, the *rend* was frequently depicted in verses that echoed the skeptical, resigned quality of Khayyam's *rubā'is* (Pandey 1995, 226–27):

The dawn is here arise my lovely one.
Pour slowly, slowly wine and touch the lute.
For those who still are here will not stay long.
While those departed never will return.

(Elwell-Sutton 1988, 157)

This is not to suggest that Babur modeled his behavior on the *rend*, on an abstract ideal, only that the model itself is reminiscent of the lives of Islamized but otherwise hard-drinking, socially uninhibited Chingizid and Timurid aristocrats—and perhaps reflective of the ruling class in Iran as well.

To evaluate Babur's *ghazals* it is important to understand that poets composed these poems after mastering the metrical and metaphorical language of their predecessors. For Babur and other writers in the Persian cultural sphere of the eastern Islamic world, the most important literary models were: Nizâmî (1140–c.1202), Sa'dî (1184–c.1292), Rûmî (1207–40), Hâfiz (1326–80), Amîr Khusrâu (1253–1325), and Jâmî (1414–92). After studying and memorizing thousands of verses of these men poets usually employed stereotypical imagery to depict idealized infatuations and generic disappointments. They exhibited creativity by devising new variants on traditional models and themes. Despite the evocative beauty and resonant emotional language of many *ghazals*, their authors, especially professional court poets, did not normally write such verse to draw attention to a subjective experience fixed in an emotional moment. Instead, poets usually depicted literary emotions and situations quite unrelated to the experiential world. Perhaps it is fitting that as this verse became more formulaic and abstracted the beloved became more ambiguous and probably irrelevant: often a man and sometimes still a woman (Meisami 1987, 245–61 and Naim 1979). Referring to this abstracted quality of the Turkic verse derived from classical Persian models, the Georgian Turcologist Elizbar Javelidze has categorically argued that:

Near Eastern mediaeval literature gives no example of a concrete man with his individual psyche and his unique psychological level; it does not render his personal feelings, his joys and sorrows. It makes an abstraction of the individual.

(Javelidze 1983, 268)

Even if this assessment is too extreme, most modern literary scholars share Javelidze's general outlook, also arguing, for example, that the device of the *takballus*, the seemingly autobiographical reference in the final couplet, ought to be interpreted as a literary device rather than as a personal allusion.

Such poems find one of their most compelling analogies in the literary precursors and characteristics of Shakespeare's sonnets—even to the homoerotic or androgynous qualities of many of his first 126 poems. The sonnets have repeatedly taxed the ingenuity of scholars, who have in turn strained the credulity of readers in searching for autobiographical clues to a poorly documented life amid the memorable language of the sonnets. In a similar way many students of Hafiz have exerted exceptional but largely unproductive efforts to detect personal references in his *ghazals*. A recent critic's remarks about the sonnets as sources for Shakespeare's life would be accepted by most scholars as equally applicable to the lyric poems of Hafiz or to those of most classical Persian, Ottoman, and Turki poets.

Biographical reading, as we understand it now, has so little purchase on these poems that criticism directed along such lines soon finds itself spinning off the text into vacuous literary chit-chat.

(Kerrigan 1986, 11)

The analogy is neither casual nor the similarity accidental, for as the *ghazal* is commonly thought to be rooted in the *nasib*, the opening couplet of the *qasidah*, “for most renaissance writers poetry was rooted in panegyric” (Kerrigan 1986, 18; Roche 1989, chap. 1). Even more particularly the authors of Elizabethan sonnets often explicitly derived their poems from the example of Petrarch's *Rime Sparse*. Petrarch's fourteenth-century sequence, focused on the mystical Laura, had much the same defining influence on sixteenth-century English sonneteers as did Hafiz's *ghazals* on the Persian and Turkic lyric poets of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. Just as it is more reasonable to interpret Petrarch's Laura and Shakespeare's “dark lady” as literary rather than autobiographical personalities, the same is true of the beloved in the *ghazals* of Hafiz. Many of Babur's lyric poems may also be fairly interpreted as literary exercises. Unlike Shakespeare and Hafiz, though, Babur was not a professional writer nor was his life undocumented. Not only does he discuss his own poetry and locate some verses in his prose narrative, but he always uses his own name, not a pen name in the *maqta'*.

Turki and the Turan Poems

When sometime after his twelfth year Babur began composing verse, Persian was still the dominant literary tradition in the Timurids' Central Asian homelands. Hafiz, whom Nava'i called the “chief person of truth,” was that tradition's towering exemplar for lyric poets (Bertels 1965, 43). The continuing prestige of Persian is exemplified by Babur's own practice of quoting Persian rather than Turki poets when he wished to cite aphorisms to punctuate his prose narrative. Most often he chose well-known sayings from Sa'di's *Gulistân*. The vocabulary, metaphors, and prosody of Persian verse were studied by Turco-Mongol aristocrats and aspiring professional poets alike. Nava'i himself argued that it was easier for young Turki-speaking poets to write in Persian than to compose verse in their native tongue as every type of “phrase and eloquence”

was readily available in that highly developed literary language (Bertels 1965, 44). While the *ghazals* and other Persian poetic genres had become increasingly formulaic, contrived, and obscure in the hands of most authors by the late fifteenth century, Persian still remained the model for cultivated writers (Bertels 1965, 45). Nonetheless, a Turki literary culture had begun to emerge in Central Asia in post-Mongol times. This occurred first, evidently, in the Aral Sea kingdom of Khwarezm in the fourteenth century and then more cohesively and permanently in Timurid courts of Central Asia and northeastern Iran in the fifteenth century.

Nava'i reported that eight Timurid rulers wrote Turki verse before Babur, but it was Nava'i himself who intentionally created a sophisticated body of verse in Turki in order to establish it as a new literary language, one that could rival and surpass Persian. Nava'i lived during what might be described as the "Turki intermezzo," to borrow Vladimir Minorsky's memorable phrase, the "Persian intermezzo," for the post-Arab, pre-Mongol period in which Islamic Persian had time to take root. That is, for all the Perso-Islamic influences in Timurid culture Turki was established as a legitimate prose and verse medium in Central Asia during his lifetime in the second half of the fifteenth century. Important rulers such as Nava'i's friend and patron Sultan Husain Baiqara probably stimulated this process by institutionalizing a distinction between the Turkic ruling class and Iranian officials and literati at his Harat court, where he established separate Turkic and Iranian assemblies (Subtelny 1991, 262). This formal recognition plus the weight of so many Turki-speaking officials must have encouraged the growth of a separate Turkic literary/cultural identity. Nava'i explicitly exalted Turki as a literary vehicle that could compete with and in certain respects surpass Persian as a poetic language in his Turki essay, *Muhâkamat al-Lughatain*, *The Judgement of Two Languages* (Devereux 1966).

By this essay Nava'i did not mean that poetical Turki was to be a vigorous, direct, idiomatic alternative to baroque, allusive, classical Persian verse; it was not to be the Italian to the classicists' Latin. He believed that Turki possessed the raw materials for elaborate metaphors, puns, and the wordplay that cultivated taste required for Persian *ghazals*, *rubâ'is*, and *masnavis*. As Nava'i wrote:

If anyone truly ponders and reflects sufficiently he will realize the plenitude and scope of Turkish vocabulary which facilitate the arts of eloquence and narrative style. . . . When [Turki poets] indulged in hyperbole, they should have done so equally in both languages.

(Devereux 1966, 45–46)

Like their Ottoman counterparts many Turki poets had so thoroughly assimilated Persian genres and imagery that often only their verbs were Turki. Nearly all used substantial amounts of Perso-Arabic and Persian vocabulary, including the Persian *ezâfe* for modifiers and possessive constructions. As the modern Turkish scholar Nasrullah el-Tirâzî has demonstrated, it was a simple process, a mechanical one really, for an Ottoman poet to create Ottoman verse from an Hafiz *ghazal* by merely substituting an Ottoman verb for a Persian one and leaving the remainder of the verse unchanged (Silay 1994, 33). Some of Babur's poems—and those of Nava'i also—fall into this category.

As Babur's letter to him from Samarqand testifies, Nava'i was a famous poet in 1500, just before his death. Nineteen years later when Babur was wintering in Kabul, he copied Nava'i's "odes and couplets" [*ghazallâr ve abyat(lâr)*] (Mano 1995, 394). He studied the verse of Nava'i, as thousands of Persian poets had memorized poems

of Nizami, Hafiz, and others, in order to master the Turki literary craft, albeit a recently established tradition. Babur, thus, had a prestigious model for his own Turki compositions. Nineteen years earlier, though, he did not have the leisure that he enjoyed in Kabul and may not have had access to the entire corpus of Nava'i's work. He may have been one of Nava'i's young Turki poets who found it easier to inaugurate his literary career with the formulaic structures and stock verbal images of Persian verse. At least his first acknowledged verse that he quotes in the *Babur-nama* was one of two Persian couplets he wrote in Andijan in 1500, shortly after his first marriage. These two lines could be excerpted from hosts of similar Persian *ghazals* and *rubai's*, although in the couplet he was not conducting a literary exercise but offering a stereotypical sentiment to describe his infatuation for the boy, Baburi, whom he had encountered in the Andijan bazar.

هیچکس چون من خراب و عاشق و رسوا مباد
هیچ محبوبی جو تو بیرحم و بی پروا مباد

May no person be as ravaged, lovesick and humiliated, as I,
May no lover be as pitiless and unconcerned, as thou.

(Mano 1995, 111–12)

This *bayt* or couplet could be interpreted as nothing more than another stereotypical, abstracted love poem in which the gender of the beloved, *tû*, is characteristically ambiguous. Within the context of the *Babur-nama*, however, the couplet seems to be a culturally appropriate literary vehicle that an inexperienced teenage poet might employ to express a genuine emotion. It also stands as an example of how a particular verse might indeed be homoerotic and not just an abstracted literary exercise. It is an especially interesting sentiment to express just after his first marriage, albeit one coerced by his mother, for like Shakespeare Babur was a married man—eventually many times over—with many children. These events—his first marriage, infatuation with the boy Baburi, and the composition of the poem—together stand as a cautionary tale against simplistic generalizations about emotional and sexual stereotypes in renaissance literature, whether Elizabethan or Timurid. The ambiguity inherent in Persian and Turki pronouns means that it is impossible to make facile characterizations based upon one or two literary allusions, and this will be even more apparent when Babur's poems from the Kabul period are examined below.

Even though Babur wrote his first couplet in Persian, he chose Turki for most of his later verse. All of the poems that he mentions writing within the year following his marriage and first love were in Turki, and apart from his familiarity with Nava'i's prestigious example, he may have chosen Turki for several reasons. Babur obviously heard Persian spoken and Persian poetry recited while growing up in Andijan. He mentions that his father read verse of the Caucasian Persian poet Nizami, the Indo-Persian sufi poet Amir Khusrau, and the most famous sufi poet of the Mongol period, Jalal al-Din Rumi. In his narrative for the years 1500–2 Babur himself quotes verses from Sa'di's *Bûstân* and *Gulistân*. Yet until his twelfth year he lived in Andijan's predominantly Turki linguistic environment where, he mentions, all the population were Turks and knew Turki, which was, as he remarks, the language of Nava'i (Thackston 1996, 36). Apart from the Turco-Mongol elite, some merchants, and the

better educated members of sufi orders and the *'ulamâ*, probably very few in Andijan spoke Persian or used it regularly. Babur's childhood education also ended abruptly in his twelfth year when his father died, and until the last few years of his life in India he did not possess a regularly constituted court with large numbers of courtiers who had grown up speaking and writing Persian. Then too he was writing for a Turki-speaking audience, a consideration that may have reinforced his bias in favor of his—and Nava'i's—language.

That his Turki heritage exerted a dominant influence is suggested by the next poem that he discusses in the *Babur-nama* after the Persian couplets, a Turki *rubai*. He wrote it in response to a Persian quatrain, in fact a verse petition which an aspiring courtier, Mulla Bîna'i, offered to him. After Babur had taken Samarqand in 1500, this man inundated him with *qasidabs* and *ghazals* in his attempt to win an appointment or a land grant (Thackston 1996, 123–24). If Babur had felt comfortable in Persian it seems that he would have shown his prowess by responding to Mulla Bina'i with a Persian *rubai* of his own. Yet for him to have spontaneously composed such a poem on an idiosyncratic subject would have required considerably greater command of the language than the knowledge he needed to cobble together stock phrases for generic Persian love couplets. Even this Turki *rubai* was not a very accomplished or interesting verse. Babur himself was dismissive of it. It was not until two years later that he began seriously to study the craft of poetry.

In July 1502, after Babur had fled to his Khan dada in Tashkent, he exploited his enforced leisure and began to sharpen his skills as a Turki poet. First in June he solicited the Khan's opinion of a Turki *rubai* that he had apparently written a few days earlier, and shortly afterwards, during a classic Mongol hunt, he completed his first Turki *ghazal*. Neither of these poems represents stereotypical lyric verse, although each conforms to the appropriate rhyme scheme for its genre. Babur evidently composed the Turki quatrain as an occasional poem in response to his refugee status. The *ghazal*'s significance is more ambiguous, but it too is probably an occasional poem, that is one written in response to a specific event or situation. Like the *rubai* it seems to reflect emotions aroused by defeat, betrayal, and exile that Babur powerfully conveys in the prose text of the *Babur-nama*.

Exile is a leitmotif of Babur's political life—from Ferghana, Samarqand, and finally from Kabul, for which the *ghazal*'s typical vocabulary “celebrating” the agonies and frustrations of unrequited love supplied a convenient vocabulary. In this Turki quatrain he gave vent to these feelings for the first time.

یاد ایتماس ایمیش کیشی نی محنت ته کیشی
شاد ایتماس ایمیش کونگنی غربت ته کیشی
کونگنوم بو غریبلیق ته شاد اولمادی [هیچ]
غربت ته سیوونماس ایرمیش البته کیشی

No one cares for a man in peril.
No one gladdens the exile's heart.
My heart has found no joy in this exiled state.
No one takes the slightest joy from exile.

(Mano 1995, 148)

Babur must have written this as more than just a literary experiment, and its carefully crafted multiple internal rhymes, which occur in such numbers in only a few other poems, suggest that it was such an experiment. It also seems like a graceful petition and perhaps a polite rebuke to his Khan dada, whose metrical failings were overshadowed by his refusal to offer Babur an alternative fief to Andijan or military aid to recover it. Whatever Babur's motives, the *rubā'i* is the first indication in the *Babur-nama* that he was prepared to exploit traditional lyric genres to express his own intense frustrations. While Persian literary tradition tolerated this in the *rubā'i*, few poets took such liberties with *ghazals*. Yet Babur apparently did so in his first Turki *ghazal* written just a short time later.

The *matla'*, the opening couplet of Babur's first complete Turki *ghazal*, reads like an emotional echo of the "exile" *rubā'i* he read to his Khan dada. Like that poem, the *matla'* contains multiple internal rhymes.

جانیم دین اوزگا یار وفادار تاپمادیم
گونگوم دین اوزگا محرم اسرار تاپمادیم

Except my soul no trustworthy friend have I found.
Except my heart no intimate confidante have I found.

(Mano 1995, 150)

Babur inserts only this bayt or couplet in the *Babur-nama*, but he describes it as the opening lines of a *ghazal*, which he reports finishing while hunting with his Khan dada near Tashkent. The entire poem appears in his *diwan*. In the opinion of the Russian Turcologist and literary scholar I. V. Stebleva, this *matla'* is an atypical opening for *ghazals* of the period, which would normally begin with an evocation of the beloved. She argues that Babur makes a sudden semantic shift in the second couplet, a shift of focus, that is, closer to the stereotypical imagery of the classic lyric poem.

جانیمدیک اوزگا جان دل افکار کورمادیم
گونگوم کیبی گونگولنی گرفتار تاجمادیم

Except my soul I have not seen a soul as melancholy.
I have not found a captive heart similar to mine.

That imagery is then unmistakable in the third couplet.

اسروک کوزیکا تا که گونگول بولدی مبتلا
هرگز بو تیلبه نی ینه هشیار تاجمادیم

Since the heart was afflicted by his/her intoxicating eyes.
Never again have I become sober after such madness.

The remaining couplets adhere to the classic *ghazal* format, and Babur concludes with a *takballus* in the first hemistich of the *maqta'* or concluding couplet.

بابر اوزونگنی اور کاتاکور یارسیز...

Babur, teach thyself to be loveless.

(Stebleva 1982, 209)

Whether or not Babur wrote the last five couplets at the same time as the *matla'* he quotes in the text is impossible to determine, although it is likely that he wrote all of the verses of the poem between 1501 and 1502. This poem seems to be an early example of the complexities of Babur's compositions, a case where he fits a couplet composed as an occasional verse to stereotypical lines of a classic *ghazal*. In her exhaustive analysis of this poem Stebleva does not discuss this particular question of composition. She is convinced, though, that this *ghazal* is one of many examples of Babur's poetry that represents an exception to the acknowledged difficulty of relating art to life—or to a particular life—in the verse of premodern Muslim poets. Stebleva observes that unlike the work of most well-known writers, this poem can be dated to a specific year, 1502, a period that Babur depicts as one of the most difficult of his life, when he considered abandoning his Timurid political ambitions and fleeing to China. She persuasively argues that an aspiring poet would not have chosen such an atypical *matla'* to demonstrate his mastery of this classic lyric genre. Babur, she remarks “violated the traditional thematic norms” that dictated the poet should begin a *ghazal* with an invocation of the beloved's beauty (Stebleva 1982, 167–68). He composed the *matla'* of this poem at variance with accepted literary taste because, Stebleva believes, the *ghazal* artfully embodies “his poetical experience of completely concrete events” (Stebleva 1982, 170). She might have added that Babur was not writing in the literary milieu of the court or for a patron, but for himself, although he was obviously concerned for his literary reputation.

Babur wrote at least 118 *ghazals*, the number included in his *diwan*, but he quotes only a few of them in the *Babur-nama*. Outwardly, at least most of these poems appear to be literary exercises in the classic abstracted lyric format, although it is dangerous to assume this merely because Babur does not explain the context of their composition. However, in one of the *ghazals* that he evidently wrote in this Turan period he completely deviated from the genre's traditional lyric theme. He locates the *matla'* of this *ghazal* in the text narrative of events for the late summer of 1500, prior to his successful surprise attack on Samarqand, although he neither claims it as his own composition nor does he refer to the lines as a *matla'*. He may have written these lines as an isolated couplet and then used it to form the *matla'* of the poem that he finished a short time later. As it is numbered the twenty-first *ghazal* in his chronologically organized *diwan*, it is likely that Babur wrote the entire poem in 1500 or 1501. He uses the couplet that appears as the *matla'* of the completed poem to punctuate his bitter complaint that he had been ill-used by Khusrau Shah, a Qipchaq Turk, not a Timurid, who ruled in Qunduz in northern Afghanistan. According to Babur, Khusrau Shah, although renowned for his generosity to others, showed him no courtesy when he passed as a refugee through his territories. Babur does not mention, of course, that he himself was then a completely insignificant Timurid prince. After

railing against Khusrau Shah in prose, Babur inserts the following couplet in the *Babur-nama*.

کیم کوروبتور ای کونکول اهل جهان دین یخشلیق
کیم که اندین یخشی یوق کوز تومه اندین یخشلیق

Who, o heart, has seen good from the people of the world?
Who that has no good from them, expect no good.

(Mano 1995, 121)

The remainder of the poem is remarkable for its deviation from classic lyrical norms. While the stoic opening might blend easily into a second couplet in which the author depicts the indifference of his beloved, Babur alludes only to “heart-ravishers” but otherwise sustains a kind of existential tone throughout the remainder of the *ghazal*.

بو زمان نی نفی قیلسام عیب قیلمه ای رفیق
کورمادیم هرگز نیتایین بو زمان دین یخشی لیغ
دلربالاردین یمانلیق کیلدی محزون کنکومه
کیلما دی جانیمغه هیچ آرام جان دین یخشی لیغ
ای کونکول جون یخشیدین کوردونک یمانلیق آسروکوب
ایمدی کوز توتماق نی یعنی هر یماندین یخشی لیغ
باری ایلکا یخشی لیغ قیلغیل که موندین یخشی یوق
کیم دیکای لار دهر ارا قالدی فلاندین یخشی لیغ
یخشی لیق اهل جهادا ایستاما بابر کیبی
کیم کوروب دور ای کونکول اهل جهان دین یخشی لیغ

If I proscribe this time do not blame me, o friend.
I have never seen good in this time, what shall I do?
From heart-ravishers come evil, my afflicted heart.
Nothing good came to my soul from any tranquil soul.
O heart since you have seen so much evil from good.
Now why do you expect good from evil?
Do good to all other people for there is no good other than this.
That people will say ‘from so-and-so good was left in the world.’
Do not like Babur seek good from the people of the world.
Who, o heart, has seen good from the people of the world?

(Stebleva 1982, 229)

Even if this poem were found only in his *diwan* its unusual character would suggest that Babur wrote it as an occasional verse. Considering its placement in the *Babur-nama*, the poem has to be seen as an artful *cri de coeur*.

Kabul Lyrics

Babur had reason to dwell on the trials that he endured before he took Kabul in 1504, although he repeatedly stresses the magnitude of his problems throughout the *Babur-nama* in a way that is consistent with most autobiographical narratives (Dale 1990, 40–41). Some occasional poems of the Kabul period reflect this theme as unmistakably as his Turan lyrics. A couplet that he composed in December 1506 is one of the most obvious occasions when he used lyric genres for this purpose. He wrote it after he and a small band of retainers became lost in the deep snows of the central Afghan mountains while returning from Harat after visiting Babur's Timurid relatives, Sultan Husain Baiqara's family. Describing the episode in which they nearly perished in the cold as one of the most harrowing experiences of his life, Babur reports that at this dangerous moment he composed the following *matla'*:

چرخ نینک مین گورماگان جور و جفاسی قالدی مو؟
خسته کونکوم چیکماکان درد و بلاسی قالدی مو؟

Does there remain for me unseen any cruelty or oppression of fate?
Shall my wounded heart yet know unknown pain or suffering?

(Mano 1995, 303)

Nowhere in the *Babur-nama* does Babur again allude to this couplet, which he identifies as a *matla'*, but in his *diwan* it represents the opening lines of the forty-fifth *ghazal*, only one of two in which Babur concludes every other line with an interrogative refrain (Stebleva 1982, 253).

Babur may have completed this poem anytime after 1506; he finally arrived safely in Kabul in January 1507. Its *matla'* marks this composition as an occasional poem; it directly reflects his experience as clearly as any he had written earlier and far more so than his first Turki *ghazal* of 1502. The poem is, of course, an artistic rendering of his prose narrative. It is a literary abstraction, a poetic universalization of his near-fatal experience in which Babur utilizes typical vocabulary of the *ghazal*, the language of cruelty, oppression, and the wounded heart. Like his first Turki *ghazal*, this poem also has a semantic shift in the third couplet, where Babur complains that the sun, his metaphorical beloved, has slain him. Yet here he employs even less of the lyric genre's stock imagery—no evocation of the beloved's eyes, his/her hyacinth-like hair, the entrancing slim figure so like the archer's bow—not to mention the erotic fuzz on the cheek or the beloved's pearl-like teeth. In this poem Babur is not speaking from within the allegorical Iranian garden with its roses and nightingales (Meisami 1985). Read in isolation the final hemistich of the *maqta'*, the final couplet, could be understood as the typical complaint of the melancholy lover, but read against the *matla'* and the *Babur-nama* it seems to reflect a particular emotional moment.

تینگری اوجون دی بو عالم نینک صفاسی قالدی مو؟

Remains there any of the world's pleasures?
Speak for god's sake!

(Stebleva 1982, 253)

A particular cultural interest of this *ghazal* is that Babur uses the Turco-Mongol

word *tengri* for god. In traditional steppe religion *tengri* connoted a shamanistic “deity,” the overarching steppe sky. Babur, who genuinely professed Islam, uses the term throughout the *Babur-nama* for the Semitic Old Testament and Quranic deity, just as Iranians often employ a Persian, Indo-European word, *khudâ*, for Allah, the one god of the Arabic Quran. When he uses *tengri* in this poem he is locating himself on the Turco-Mongol end of the Islamic cultural and linguistic spectrum. Readers of the *Babur-nama* often are reminded of this fact when Babur warmly describes one of his extended drinking bouts or casually relates how he ordered the decapitation of defeated enemies, whose heads were sometimes then built into towers of skulls (Thackston 1996, 387). Mongols and Timurids employed the latter practice as a terror tactic to inspire submission, and Babur’s grandson, Akbar, did so also in his campaigns against the Rajputs in the late sixteenth century.

In contrast to the querulous tone of this “blizzard” poem, Babur cites verses in the *Babur-nama* for two other genuinely lyrical *ghazals* that he wrote during the Kabul period. These verses suggest that he had become a more inventive, subtle poet in the classical Persian poetic tradition. They may also reflect a more relaxed and confident mood when he enjoyed the relative security of his Kabul base, even if it was an impoverished capital compared to Andijan and Agra. These *ghazals* reveal new facets of the diverse ways in which Babur’s poetry may have been linked with the events of his life. Both poems are more refractions than direct reflections. Their compositions offer examples of muted, indirect connections between Babur’s verse and his life, quite distinct creative relationships from the 1506 blizzard poem or the exile *rubai* of 1502.

Babur dates the first of these *ghazals* to 21 March 1505, the spring solstice and *naurûz*, the new year of the Iranian solar calendar. He remarks that in 1505 this major pre-Islamic festival coincided with ‘Îd al-Fitr, the date on the Islamic lunar calendar when Muslims celebrate the end of the Ramadan fast. Babur may, though, have mistaken these dates, for Stebleva adroitly observes that the festivals more nearly coincided in 1504 (Stebleva 1982, 174–75). In any event it seems likely that this unusual conjunction stimulated him to compose the poem, or at least to write the *matla’* and *maqta’*, for he begins and ends the *ghazal* with allusions to this coincidence and a literary play on the metaphorical significance of the moon as the face of the beloved. In fact, Babur quotes only these opening and concluding couplets in the *Babur-nama*, perhaps because only these lines contain his witty imagery.

يانكى آي يار يوزى بيرله گوروب ايل شاد بيرم لار
مكا يوز و قاشينكدين اير و بيرم آيدا غم لار

-----bayts 2-6.

يوزى نوروزى وصلى عيدىنى بابر غنيمت توت
كه موندن يخشى بولماس بولسه يوز نوروز[و] بيرم لار

On seeing the new moon with the beloved’s face,
people are joyous at the festivals.
As for me separated from thy face and brows,
the festivals are sad.

—couplets 2–6.

Babur, seize the moment of this festive conjunction,
the face of the new year.

Festivals could not be better than this even with
a hundred new years.

(Mano 1995, 231)

The five middle couplets contain stereotypical lyrical imagery that has none of the inventiveness of these first and last lines. They describe first how the lyrical hero's infatuation causes his body to twist, similar to the hyacinth-like curls on the face of the beloved. Then blown aside by the lover's breath the beloved's tresses reveal the perspiration on his/her face resembling evening dew on a rose. Finally, lamenting with "sighs and groans and bloody tears," which Babur contrasts with quiet convivial drinking sessions with companions, he says that advice is useless for him because love has destroyed his heart (Stebleva 1982, 223).

If the unusual conjunction of *naurûz* and 'Id inspired Babur to compose this *ghazal*, he was moved to write another lyric in 1507 after he visited the flower-strewn mountain meadows of *Gulbahâr*, the "Rose" or "Flower of Spring" slope north of Kabul. Viewing this *daman* or mountain skirt, Babur enthusiastically praises its tulips as well as the hawking and bird-shooting available there. He remarks that "In the spring the plains of Chash Töpä, and the hills of Gulbahar are extremely beautiful. Compared to other places in the province of Kabul the greenery there is luxurious. All sorts of tulips blossom" (Thackston 1996, 250). The poem he wrote on this occasion illustrates the interpenetration of art and life—or of poetry and this particular life. Sa'di and Hafiz set so many of their *ghazals* in gardens that Babur or anyone with poetic ambitions and remotely familiar with the oft-sung verses of these poets would probably have memorized hundreds of paradisiacal literary settings. Nothing would have been more natural, or more culturally suggested, than for an aspiring lyric poet to respond to visions of wildflowers in spring pastures with a *ghazal*. Given the name of this slope, *Gulbahar*, the Flower of Spring, the temptation must have been irresistible. Babur responded to this scene as most other classically trained writers probably would have done. He ignored the natural beauty before him and reached into the stereotypical lyric vocabulary, composing a *ghazal* more nearly congruent with the traditional genre than any he mentions in the *Babur-nama* up to this time. Here was the interiorized, self-referential poetic *gulistan* or rose garden that Frances Pritchett has shown to be the self-contained literary garden of later Indo-Muslim Urdu poets, writers who found it so intoxicating that they might close their windows to the actual beauties of nature (Pritchett 1994, 104)! While Babur says that he finished the entire poem at this time, in his narrative he quotes only the *matla'*, which Annette Beveridge, the early-twentieth-century English translator of the *Babur-nama* artfully rendered, with echoes of Robert Burns, as:

My heart, like the bud of a red, red rose
Lies fold within fold aflame;
Would the breath of even a myriad Springs
Blow my heart's bud to a rose?

(Beveridge 1969, 321)

The text of the entire *ghazal* with a more prosaic translation is as follows:

منينك كونكلوم كه كل نينك غنجه سى ديگته ته بته قان دور
 اگر يوز مينك بهار اولسه آجيلماغي نى امكان دور
 انر اول قاشى ياسيز باغ گشتين آرزو قيلسام
 كوزومكا اوق دورور سرو و كونكولكا غنجه بىكان دور
 بهار و باغ سيرينى نى قيلاي كيم داستانيم نينك
 يوزى كول زلفى سنبل قامتى سرو خرامان دور
 وصالى لذتى دين روح تاجماغليق ايرور دشوار
 فراقى شديندا يوقسا جان بيرماكليك آسان دور
 باشيدين ايورولور ارمانى بيرلا اولدوم اى بابر
 منينك نعيم نى بارى اول پرى كوييدين ايلان دور

 Petal upon petal, my heart is like the rosebud.
 If there would be even 100,000 springs it would not open.
 If I wished to pass through the garden without the one whose brow is a bow
 The flowering cypress would be like an arrow for the eye
 and a fire for the heart.
 Why should I stroll in the garden in spring,
 since in my poem
 The beloved's face is a flower, his/her hair—a hyacinth
 and body—a cypress.
 Finding ease in the pleasure of union is difficult.
 While relinquishing life due to the pain of separation is easy.
 O Babur, could I die encircled with sighs about his/her brow.
 Even though I encircled that fairy-like realm in my bier.

(Stebleva 1982, 254).

Stebleva remarks of this lyric that in most cases any attempt to find a biographical use for such a *ghazal* “would be extremely strained and very doubtful” (Stebleva 1982, 178). It would, that is, be analogous to the “vacuous literary chit-chat” of scholars who strain to link Shakespeare’s sonnets to the Elizabethan poet’s life. Alluding to Babur’s prose narrative of his visit to Gulbahar, she remarks that in this instance, however, “we have documentary proof” of the association between an event and a literary composition (Stebleva 1982, 178). The first line of the third couplet, in which Babur delights in the spring and the garden, represents the link between that event and this composition.

Babur is likely to have written many of the 118 *ghazals* and more than 200 *rubāʿis* that are included in his *diwan* during the nearly twenty-two years that he ruled in Kabul. Unfortunately, there is a nearly seventeen-year gap in the extant text for this period, from 1509 to 1519 and from 1519 to 1526, pages that Humayun, his son and heir, may have lost when the resurgent Afghans forced him to flee India in 1540. Thus poems that he probably included in the text for these years are now found only in his *diwan*. However, the *ghazals* and *rubāʿis* of Babur’s *diwan* appear to be chronologically organized, deviating from the tradition of alphabetical ordering by

rhyme that renders the collections of nearly all the great poets useless for the study of literary development, or for biography (Rypka 1968, 96). A careful study of his *diwan* might yield important conclusions about the evolution of his poetic art, particularly when it is recalled that Babur says he completed a study of Nava'i's four *diwans* in 1519 (Thackston 1996, 303). At least it is possible to suggest that he wrote most of his *ghazals* in this period, since the Gulbahar poem, which he dates to 1507, is numbered only forty-six in the *diwan*.

In one case a poem now found only in the *diwan* and not in the *Babur-nama* can also be dated to 1507, both on the basis of its number, forty-four, and an explicit reference to Kabul. In her ingenious analysis of this poem Stebleva not only argues that it can be dated, but that in the penultimate couplet Babur was alluding to his second engagement, to his paternal cousin, Masuma Sultan Begum, which was arranged when he visited Harat in 1506 (Stebleva 1982, 191–95). The girl was to be sent on to Kabul later after Babur returned there, and it was on this trip that Babur and his companions became marooned in mountain snows. The first six couplets of the *ghazal* are impeccably generic and of no special interest but in the sixth, using the commonly invoked metaphor *shah* for the beloved, Babur writes:

کابل ساری گر عزیمت اتسانک
قربان قیلای اوزنی سنگا شاه

If you travel on the road to Kabul,
Let me offer myself to you o Shah.

(Stebleva 1982, 252)

If Stebleva's persuasive analysis is correct, the *ghazal* was just as much an occasional poem as his first Persian couplet, even if his metaphors here were just as formulaic as in that earlier verse. The erotic focus of this poem also offers another cautionary note about basing facile and monolithic generalizations about authors' sexual orientations on a few widely scattered poems. Indeed, these two examples suggest that in most cases when such judgments are made about the poorly documented lives of premodern Muslim writers they are in fact mere "vacuous literary chitchat."

Indian "Fragments"

The complex problems involved in understanding the biographical significance of Babur's Turan and Kabul poems largely evaporate when considering the verses that he includes in the Indian section of the *Babur-nama*. Partly this reflects the fact that Babur includes so few poems in this section, probably because he left it in unrevised diary form at his death in 1530. Poems that he might have integrated into a later draft are found, without context, only in his *diwan*. He quotes no *ghazals* in the prose narrative of events from 1526–30, only *qit'as* or "fragments," and these pose no interpretative problems. The Iranian scholar Ziya Mauhad has recently defined the *qit'a* as a "type of verse in a single measure (or rhythm) and rhyme without a definite opening *misra'* which From the point of view of rhythm, rhyme, number of verses, language and subject" it offers the poet the greatest freedom (Mauhad [1373])

1994, 16). Babur used the *qit'a* as his own free verse form, a genre with no rigid thematic rules, no strict requirements of rhyme or even of length. He used the *qit'a* for informal messages or ephemeral letters or jokes, and did not regard any of them as true poetry, not including fragments, therefore, in his *diwan*. These fragments had the immediacy and particularity of prose. In his *qit'as* Babur expresses clearly and directly ideas and feelings that in lyrical genres he formulated in allegorical narrative and metaphorical language. If he had written a *qit'a* about being snowbound in 1506, readers would not have to search the poem for experiential metaphors; he would have openly described the storm, its dangers, and his feelings.

Babur wrote *qit'as* before his victory in India at the Battle of Panipat in April 1526. One of these was a jesting poem, full of puns, that he deprecatingly refers to as a “bu ghina qit'a” (this little fragment), which he sent in 1519 to his close friend, Khwaja Kalan (Thackston 1996, 272). After his Panipat victory he mentions writing several other “little fragments.” One that he composed in August 1526 exemplifies his use of the genre. It was a threat, a frank diplomatic note, perhaps softened by being expressed as a poem, to one Nizâm Khân, the commander of the fortress of Bayana, near Agra, demanding that Nizam Khan surrender the fort to Babur's men. Babur wrote it in Persian, because that was undoubtedly Nizam Khan's administrative and literary language. The poem's meaning is clear from its first distich.

با ترک ستیزه مکن ای میر بیانه

Strive not with the Turk, o Mir of Bayana.

(Mano 1995, 479)

A second example of one of these “little fragments” was a poem of eight couplets Babur sent in the summer of 1527 to some followers who had retreated to Kabul to escape the oppressive humid heat, while he was left to swelter in India. The first four lines of the *qit'a* read as follows:

ای الار کیم بو هند کشوریدین
باردینکیز انکلاب اوزکا ریغ و الم
کابل و خوش هوا سینی ساغینیب
هند دین کرم باردینکیز اول دم

Ah, those of you who have gone from Hind
Aware of its afflictions and oppression
Knowing Kabul and its good climate
You go there [escaping] from India's heat.

(Mano 1995, 527–28)

Babur's nostalgia for Kabul anticipates the aging Kangxi emperor's desire to reinvigorate himself by escaping the oppressive climate of Beijing and going hunting in the ancestral Manzhou homelands, “in the fine climate of the Mongolian regions”

(Spence 1973, 143). Both men were Central Asians who had made their fortunes in the populous and wealthy but overheated, humid south. Blocked by the Uzbeks from reoccupying their own Central Asian homelands, Babur's successors replicated a lush version of the Ferghana valley in the temperate climate of the Vale of Kashmir.

In his narrative of events that followed the Panipat victory, Babur seems to condemn all his occasional, impious verse. He has especially harsh words for just such jesting or satirical verse as this *qit'a*, or even more so the spontaneous couplets that he and his companions composed during a drunken party on a raft in December 1526. In the autumn of that year he had fallen ill, as was to happen to him so frequently in India, whose climate he and most of his nobles loathed. Ostentatiously regretting years of literary frivolity, Babur wrote:

Before this, whatever came to mind, good or bad, serious or humorous, was often put into poetry as a joke. No matter how obscene or improper, it got written down.

(Thackston 1996, 312)

Annette Beveridge believed that Babur probably inserted this and other contrite confessions of impiety and transgressions of Islamic prohibitions in the Indian pages shortly before his death in 1530 (Beveridge 1969, 449). Her argument is convincing because, as has already been seen in the evidence of the 1527 *qit'a*, he wrote many casual, occasional poems after 1526.

Nevertheless, Babur alters his tone in the Indian section, often displaying a convincing piety that is not very evident in his Turan and Kabul narratives. Poems of his *diwan* appear to reflect this altered mood. Just as a chronological reading of Tolstoy's short stories offers a compelling insight into the Russian writer's evolving emotional and spiritual preoccupations, so Babur's chronologically organized *diwan* seems to represent a literary barometer of his maturation—or physical decline. Most of the early *rubai's*, for example, are classic, stereotypical lyrics, literary exercises devoted to the lyrical hero and his unobtainable beloved. Many later *rubai's*, in contrast, display an Augustinian-like recantation of Babur's younger, profane self. That thousands of other writers, Muslim and non-Muslim, have expressed similar sentiments in old age does not render them any less meaningful to Babur. That is, these poems may represent a genre, but death is also generic and Babur was frequently sick in India, and perhaps died prematurely because of the South Asian climate. The first *rubai'i* listed in the *diwan* is an uncomplicated example of his early lyric poems, although there is no way to be certain about the exact date of its composition.

ای کلنی اوچون قاتینکدا مین خوار اولدوم
یوز محنت و اندوه بیلہ یار اولدوم
وصلینک بیلہ بسیار سویندیم اول
هجرینک بیلہ عاقبت گرفتار اولدوم

O rose I have become wretched being near you.
With a hundred troubles and afflictions I have become a lover.

After our tryst I first fell deeply in love.
After parting from you I became a captive.

(Köprülü-zâde [1331] 1915, 308)

In later poems, on the other hand, Babur regrets profane love and pleasures of all kinds, although such verses seem to be a response more to his prolonged drinking bouts than to the abstracted infatuations of classical verse. Lines from the single *masnavi* that he evidently wrote near the end of his life poignantly express such feelings, which are given special force by Babur's unusual recourse to a predominantly Arabic vocabulary, with its unmistakable Quranic religious connotations.

شہوت و نفس قوی دشمن دور

. . . Debauchery and carnality are powerful enemies . . .

نیلین مرشد و نیتای ارشاد

. . . Let me find a teacher and follow his direction . . .

(Köprülü-zâde [1331] 1915, 307)

While Babur does not contextualize either poem by quoting it in his prose narrative, the chronological organization of the *diwan* makes it feasible to surmise that both evoked distinct periods of his life.

Had Babur lived to revise the *Babur-nama* he probably would have inserted some of the *rubai's* and *ghazals* now found only in his *diwan* in appropriate sections of the prose text. His use of poems in the Turan and Kabul sections indicate that he consciously used them to heighten the artistic impact of the narrative. The last *ghazal* in the Istanbul collection might be one of these, for in it Babur artfully uses the metaphor of the lyric poet's separation from his beloved to evoke the pain of his Indian exile from Kabul and Central Asia. That is, he reiterates the exile theme of his first Turki quatrain (Köprülü-zâde [1331] 1915, 471; Stebleva 1982, 178–81). Certainly Babur wrote one *rubai* whose verses unmistakably indicate that he intended to integrate it into the text. Listed next to the last of the quatrains in his *diwan*, the second couplet of the poem reads:

هر کیم بو وقائع اوقور بیلکای کیم
نی رخ و نی محنت و نی غملار کوردوم

Everyone who reads these events will know
What grief and what sorrow and what difficulties I have seen.

(Köprülü-zâde [1331] 1915, 327)

This couplet is one of the best reasons for believing that Babur chose *vaqâ'i*, or events, as the original title of his memoir.

Conclusion

In “Personality Formation: the Determinants,” Clyde Kluckhohn and Henry Murray introduce their essay by observing:

Everyman is in certain respects:

1. Like all other men.
2. Like some other men.
3. Like no other men.

(Kluckhohn and Murray 1953, 53).

Studies of premodern Muslim poets have largely been forced to leave the impression that apart from such major attributes as raw talent or openly declared religious affiliation poets were indistinguishable. Hafiz was a master lyricist and Rumi a superb mystic poet, but the artistic and personal development of even these exceptionally popular authors is frustratingly opaque. Not every facet of Babur's life and literary career are equally well-known, but at least it is possible to see his literary life as both stereotypical and idiosyncratic, as formulaic and inimitable. He was, of course, a typical poet and a typical royal poet in many respects—in his regard for classic exemplars and emulation of traditional genres, in his desire for literary fame and cultural legitimacy. He was also a unique royal poet in many ways—in his relative freedom from the stylistic constraints of court culture and his frank willingness to use traditional genres to express his emotions. Babur's use of his own name as the *takhallus*, for which poets generally chose pen names, may be one measure of the degree to which he was prepared openly to reveal his emotions in verse. Using his name was an egoistic act, reflective, perhaps, of the compelling, self-assured personality that he revealed in the *Babur-nama*. He favorably compared himself to the greatest Timurid ruler of the day, Sultan Husain Baiqara of Harat, and felt confident enough of his literary skills to claim superiority for his essay on prosody to that of the great Nava'i, whose work on metrics Babur dismisses as “full of mistakes” (Thackston 1996, 214).

Yet Babur's poetry cannot generally be said to represent great Turki verse when measured against classical norms. His contemporaries would probably have regarded most of his own verse as stylistically simplistic and uncreative. Their attitude may be reflected in the scarcity of extant copies of Babur's *diwan*. The American literary scholar Frances Pritchett responds in just such a way to an occasional poem of the Urdu poet Azad (b. 1820). Azad, who generally wrote in the classical Persian tradition, reacted to the horrific reprisals that British troops inflicted on Delhi's Muslim population while suppressing the Indian Mutiny of 1857 by composing a *ghazal*, which in its middle verses becomes “direct and immediate” (Pritchett 1994, 24). Pritchett remarks that this poem “can only be called uninspired but it has a unique historical interest” (24). Babur's poetry is inimitable just for this reason. It offers the critical exception to Elizbar Javelidze's generalization that there was “a complete severance of medieval Near Eastern poetry from life, . . . and therefore Oriental poetry almost wholly disregards the poet's biography” (Javelidze 1983, 268). While some of Babur's poems were conventional, others could be characterized as existential, where the force of his life and personality broke through conventional norms. Sometimes he included both atypical, occasional couplets and conventional lyric lines within a single poem, exhibiting a transparent artistic tension between the personal and the generic.

He probably would not have wished his poetry to be remembered because it deviated from classical models, but his eccentricity offers a feast for biographers, even if most householders in Timurid and Uzbek Samarqand might have regarded his *diwan* as indifferent poetical fare, perhaps not even equal to the verse of Baisunghur Mirza! Yet Babur's compositions also offer more than piquant human interest. They provide a rare opportunity for literary scholars to study the artistic evolution of a premodern Muslim poet and to explore the relationship between his life and art.

A completely satisfactory literary history of Babur awaits a systematic analysis of his entire *diwan* and a close comparison of these *ghazals* and *ruba'i* with Nava'i's vast *oeuvre*. In the meantime it is interesting to reflect on the hints that Babur's verse contains for the creative relationship between poetry and prose, between literature and life. In a revealing letter that he sent to his son Humayun in 1529, he criticized his son's careless spelling and convoluted, opaquely florid prose. Babur tartly observed that prose was not the proper medium for literary tricks, which was the province of poetry. "Who [he writes to Humayun] has ever heard of prose designed to be an enigma? . . . From now on write with uncomplicated, clear and plain words" (Thackston 1996, 413). While writers of Persian prose histories often engaged in word plays with as little concern for lucidity as Humayun in his letters to his father, Babur, as has been observed, wrote with the kind of economy, directness, and clarity that he urged on his son.

Apart from *qit'as* or fragments, flippant or threatening, which he did not conceive of as true poetry, Babur's conception of the relationship between his prose narrative and his lyric poems seems to have been analogous to the relationship between his prose descriptions of natural beauty and construction of formal, Persian-style gardens in Afghanistan and India. He vividly and accurately described the countryside of Kabul and the mountain slopes of Gulbahar and Istalif in the *Babur-nama* as they actually appeared—and appear today—as an idiosyncratic, unregulated natural landscape where wild tulips, rather than cultivated roses, grew. Whereas the *Bâgh-i vafâ*, "the garden of fidelity," that he ordered built in 1508–9 represented an idealized, abstracted version of nature, a metaphor of eternity, of paradise, itself the Persian word for Iranian formal gardens. While in the *Babur-nama* he describes the natural, unregulated beauty of Gulbahar or the fall foliage at Istalif and Bihzad, in the Gulbahar *ghazal* Babur narrates an abstracted tale of the generic lyrical hero and his beloved in the metaphorical, eternal poetic garden. Only the inspiration for that particular poem is experiential.

Alexander Blok (d.1921), the Russian symbolist poet, alluded to the type of contrast between poetry and prose that is evident in Babur's writings when he defined the poet's art.

The poet is entrusted with a task—to free sounds from their natural anarchic element; to bring these sounds into harmony and give them form; to introduce this harmony into the outside world.

(Reeder 1994, 139)

Babur created the *Bâgh-i vafâ* out of nature's anarchy and the harmonious literary garden, with its roses, cypress trees, and archetypal beloveds, from the ungovernable particularities of an accurately rendered prose description of the Gulbahar *daman*. The garden and his *ghazals* and *ruba'is* were art; the *Babur-nama* and *qit'as* were not. Nearly dying in a snowstorm represented anarchic, chaotic life; abstracting that experience in a *ghazal* transmuted a particularized prose description into a universalized form,

the poetic art. Babur's poetic expression of his experiences and emotions within the narrative of the *vaqa'i*, the events of his life, offers unique insight into the creative imagination of an accessible and vivid personality.

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